UPFRONT

HEALTH WATCH: MONSOON FLU *PG 22*

GRAPHIC: REDRAWING DIASPORA *PG 24*



ON EDGE A police vehicle torched by the demonstrators in Leh, Sept. 24

AFP

▶ LADAKH

HIMALAYAN STORM FOR STATEHOOD

Leh's demands for constitutional safeguards lead to violence and a high-profile arrest, exposing the fragility of New Delhi's Ladakh experiment

By KALEEM GEELANI

LADAKH, THE ICE-COLD DESERT WITH A MOONSCAPE, was one of the most placid places on the Indian map—till September 24, that is. That's when arson and violence shattered its long calm, leaving four dead and dozens injured in its wake. If any other sign was needed to show how abnormal things were, Sonam Wangchuk—iconic innovator, Magsaysay awardee, climate activist—was in jail.

Evidently, beneath Ladakh's serene topsoil, there had been stirrings of a volcanic unrest. Its sudden eruption, if anything, exposes the fragility of New Delhi's political experiment in this northern outpost. Since Ladakh's separation from Jammu and Kashmir on August 5, 2019, and rebirth as a Union Territory, its demands have been getting louder: not only jobs, but full statehood, a legislature, inclusion under the Sixth Schedule (which provides for self-administration of tribal areas), land rights and full control over its ecology. During